HARD QUESTIONS



- **Can we be a great nation without knowing which side of the road to drive on?**
- **Can we be a great nation with ever-rising mountains of garbage surrounding our urban centres?**
- **Can we be a great nation if our election funding is open to question?**
- **Can we be a great nation if most of our cities and towns are choking with pollution?**
- **Can we be a great nation when lynching or beating a person to death becomes commonplace?**
- **Can we be a great nation when we are regarded as the rape capital of the world and violence against women is treated as a routine affair?**
- **Can we be a great nation by confusing disagreement with dissent, dissent with disloyalty and disloyalty with treason?**
- **Can we be a great nation if we live in fear of our government?**

Becoming an economic giant is not an end in itself, we must also become a Great Nation. Just like GDP, we should also measure GDB, or Gross Domestic Behaviour. So that nation-building goes hand in hand with character-building

Today, India accounts for a little over 3 per cent of global manufacturing and China a little over 28 per cent. In five years, we should aim for an 8 per cent global share. Remember, in 1995, China had only 3 per cent share.

Lastly, we are on our way to becoming the third-largest economy in the world in terms of GDP. But becoming an economic giant is not an end by itself. We have to become a Great Nation. We cannot rise economically and descend in our conduct and our character.

- Can we be a great nation without knowing which side of the road to drive on? Every year, nearly 10,000 Indians lose their lives in accidents caused by people driving on the wrong side of the road.
- Can we be a great nation with ever-rising mountains of garbage surrounding our urban centres?
- Can we be a great nation if our cities and towns are choking with pollution?
- Can we be a great nation when lynching or beating a person to death becomes commonplace?
- Can we be a great nation when we are regarded as the rape capital of the world and violence against women is treated as a routine affair?
- Can we be a great nation if our election funding is open to question?
- Can we be a great nation by confusing disagreement with dissent, dissent with disloyalty and disloyalty with treason?
- Can we be a great nation if we live in fear of our government?

There are many more hard questions like these that I am sure you ask yourself every day. I think most of you know the answer.

We need to measure what I call Gross Domestic Behaviour—GDB if you like—just as we measure GDP. So that nation-building goes hand in hand with character-building. So that when we become an economic giant, we also become a social and moral giant.

Twenty years ago—2003, to be precise—President Clinton had told the India Today Conclave something that has remained in my mind. He said, "I have no doubt India will be a giant. But what kind of giant? You must become a global giant, and of the right kind."

So here's to becoming the Right Kind of Giant. ■